

The Christian and the Human as Opposites in the Consciousness of Our Time

[Det Kristelige og det Humane som Modsætninger i vor Tids Bevidsthed]

I–III

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I.

What comes forth in our time as a struggle between faith and knowledge is, despite the central significance of this opposition, nevertheless only a particular expression of a more comprehensive struggle: the struggle between the Christian and the Human; and in this struggle Christianity, as the highest and concluding form of the positive religions, as their purest and most spiritualized expression, represents in turn something more universal: the positively religious in its opposition to the free human. In this last shape the opposition has already for millennia been pronounced for consciousness: it broke forth as soon as human thought, bold and strong, had found its law and its norm in thought itself, as soon as, in existence — which it now wished to cognize for itself, not to have explained to it through the riddles of myth — it had found the same reason that is its own essence.

[290] Already in the antiquity of Greece free thought came into opposition to the form of the positively religious that was given in the Greek popular religion. The many gods with their strife and struggle, with their human passions, with their human destinies, in short, with all their finitude, became a stumbling block for the thought that sought in the whole of existence only the One that reason acknowledges, the all-encompassing, all-governing, infinite, in which it can find rest. And thought's opposition to the gods of the popular faith became an opposition that encompassed the *whole* of human life. As soon as thought had found in itself its own law as the law of existence, the human will too had to be seen as governed by this law: in the demand of reason, not in the command of a foreign will or in the prescriptions of a priesthood, the norm for human action had to be sought. In cognition and in will the human spirit then sought the regulating principle in itself, not by detaching itself from the whole of existence, but by comprehending itself as a living member of this whole, and by finding in itself, as indwelling and akin to it in essence, the divine that was the ground of itself and of all existence. On this ground it rested securely, without any secret sense of lacking what thought was combating; and where Greek philosophy reaches its high point, in Aristotle, spirit stands in the free clarity of thought, in the secure consciousness of its unity with the divine reason, which in its unfolding is the life of the universe, calm and free over against a faith in which it

sees only single glimpses of truth wrapped in the motley cover of mythic images, in the involuntary veiling of fantasy or the deliberate veiling of calculating cleverness.

Under changing forms, but yet in its essence constantly the same, the opposition between the free human and the positively religious comes forth in the Christian era. From the beginning the struggle is that of the new revelation, of the divine truth, against that wisdom of the world in which the spiritual is to find a place by God's wisdom triumphing over man's. Here the Christian is what contends against the sanctioned, the established, what has been holy from antiquity, as the wisdom of the world also comes to include the faith that had originally grown up out of the natural ground of human life, and which is now seen in the same light as the thought that once combated [291] it. Christianity fights here, weak in the outward but mighty in the inward, because what it combats is the outlived, whose time of unfolding is past, whose root in consciousness has dried up, that which no longer satisfies the demands of life, because it expresses the human only one-sidedly and incompletely. It triumphs as it seems to succumb: from the blood of the martyrs the church rises up as the church triumphant, whose cross waves above the armies of the Roman state, whose spiritual power rises up from the imposing foundation of an earthly power.

In another form the struggle comes forth in the Middle Ages. Against the entrenched power of the church, represented by a priesthood spread over the lands, gathered in one apex in the Vicar of Christ, who in the world's old capital rules spiritually over "the city and the world", the fight is waged not only from the side of the state, the secular power, but from the side of that science which the church wishes to make its handmaid and, as it were, to shut up in a monastery cell, far from nature and far from the naturally determined life of society. Thought, which willingly and trustingly subordinated itself to the church, which strained its strength to solve the task the church had set it: to join the dogmas together into the unity of an ecclesiastical doctrine, whose divine truth, to be sure, was not to be comprehensible to the human spirit, but was yet to be capable of being maintained by it as something not-impossible; — this thought grew imperceptibly under the relation of servitude, and as it grew, there awoke its consciousness of its own laws, its need for freedom and its need for actuality. From the object that, as the unappropriable and incomprehensible, could be shaped only in an outward manner, thought turned toward the appropriable content of actuality, which it could draw from a nature that no longer frightened it back as something foreign, and which it could fetch up from the human spirit's own depths. As philosophy, science separated itself from theology, free thought from bound thought, and the opposition which in the earlier Middle Ages had [292]

been able to remain concealed stood, at the close of the Middle Ages, clear and sharp before consciousness. "One is the truth of theology, another that of philosophy" now became the watchword, and with that the divorce was accomplished, secular science emancipated. The church could still brand as heretics, but its power over minds was no longer the same as when an emperor, barefoot and in penitent's garb, had humbly to beg a pope for release from the ban, and when the foremost of thought had to recant before the councils what thought affirmed and the church denied.

At the beginning of the modern age the struggle then became a struggle between emancipated science and the medieval-scholastic theology, bound by dogma and governed by the uncomprehended and incomprehensible; and from this weaker opponent science soon turned against dogma itself. In the time when antiquity was reborn and the human spirit turned back with enthusiasm to the classical models in life and poetry, in art and science, in order to seek in them a content that it could appropriate and find nourishment in, the struggle was waged with passion, and in this struggle philosophy got its martyrs. Soon, however, the opposition assumed a calmer shape. Science soon no longer needed to fight for its existence; secured by its own strength, it became a power of life that compelled recognition, and against which the divided church had to defend itself. The *whole* of modern philosophy, in its double form as realistic and idealistic, stands by its principle in opposition to the positively religious, as this is represented by Christianity, and the *whole* of modern natural science is foreign to it. What Christianity denies — nature — is the foundation of modern science, and human thought, which Christianity sees as dimmed and darkened by sin, which has disturbed its essence, and as led to truth only by revelation, becomes for modern philosophy a source of truth, its governing power its own laws, which it finds confirmed in nature. And by science's opposition to [293] the positively religious the general consciousness of our time is determined, directly or indirectly. In the whole view of the world and of life of the modern age the opposition is pronounced to positive religion's holding fast to a foreign, superhuman and supernatural law and norm for cognition and action. For the human consciousness the essentiality of nature as the foundation of human life stands firm, and it does not doubt "the capacity of unaltered, complete human nature to attain, from out of its own interior, to the truth of cognition and of action, the source of which the human essence harbors within itself." And this human consciousness, which distances itself from positive religion, finds in itself the living source of the ideally religious by going back to the ground of its essence, to its fundamental relation to the eternal power of existence.

Everywhere in the lands that lead the cultural development of the modern age we

find in our time the opposition between the Human and the positively religious sharply pronounced and clearly conscious; and in the many forms, merely heterogeneous to a superficial glance, in which the Human expresses itself, it is not difficult to find the pervasive features, and in the deeper and more serious of these forms there shows itself everywhere a striving to find, in the very depths of human nature, a richer and truer substitute for what the positively religious once provided the spirit. More and more strongly the power of the Human asserts itself in the course of cultural development, as the wealth of human nature unfolds ever more fully before consciousness; more and more it frees itself from the constraining bonds of the past. Only in the lands that lie outside the cultural current or at its outer edges does the old retain to a certain degree its significance for the spirit and its power over it. Here one can then see the peculiar phenomenon that precisely this holding fast to the old is interpreted as a sign that it is these lands in which the true vital force has been preserved, that it is they who are to lead the future history of humanity, while the great cultured peoples are supposed to be outlived and spiritually exhausted. One forgets to draw a historical parallel that [294] lies close at hand. When the faith of antiquity withered away and a new power of life rose triumphant, it was not at those points of the old world where the life of thought was strongest, the current of culture mightiest, that the old faith put up the longest and toughest resistance. It was in out-of-the-way regions, in provinces that fed on old memories, on recollections of vanished greatness; it was in small towns and villages that the old was preserved, and the name paganism for the old heathendom recalls this relation. The same thing repeats itself in our time with regard to the faith of the Middle Ages; but now people take pride in belonging to the »pagani«.

Under all the changing forms that the opposition between the positively religious and the Human has assumed from the first Christian era until our days, there is one phenomenon that must attract attention: it is the immobility of the Christian view of life beneath its apparent development. Only to a fleeting glance does a development show itself in the Christian view of life; what assumes the appearance of one is only the reflection of the opposition's alternation, or the amalgamating of the Christian with elements inconsistently taken up from what is foreign. In the Human there shows itself a possibility of development as rich as its essence, infinite as this; in the Christian view of life there is, and must be, immobility, both because of its abstraction, of its nature-less spirituality, and because of its boundness to authority. This boundness is, essentially regarded, equally great in Protestantism and Catholicism. Catholicism has an advantage

in that tradition in it is at every moment borne by a living individuality on whom the currents of the spirit of the age can exert their influence; but the infallible head of the [295] church himself is nevertheless so bound by the sum of tradition that piles up behind him that there can be no room for a free development. It is the same power of tradition, only halted at a definite point — at the Scripture, which is itself only the monument to the tradition of a single Christian age — that in Protestantism binds free inquiry and free development. When the Reformation protested against the tradition of Catholicism and, in agreement with the general striving of the Renaissance, of which the ecclesiastical reformation was only a single, limited expression, took refuge back in the original, this original was not what is primitive in the human spirit — the spirit's freedom in thought and action — but what is first in the sense of finite time: Christianity's first historical monuments; and one took refuge back in them only in order, for the benefit of the scriptural tradition, to renounce the right of thought, the autonomy of action, in order to submit to an outward, abiding norm, more binding than that of Catholicism.

When it is frequently asserted that the general spiritual movement of our time is going back toward the positively religious, that there is generally a need making itself felt in minds to take this up again, this assertion rests on a confusion. One confuses the religious, which is a necessary moment in the fully conceived human, an expression of human nature itself in its vital connection with the indwelling divine, with what is expressed in the form of the positive religions. Of the former that assertion would in essentials be correct; of the latter it is untrue. It is that religious element — which the spiritless materialism of the 18th century and its renewal in our days have sought to displace — that there is now a striving, from so many sides, in all the deeper and more genuine forms of the human direction of spirit, to reinstate in its right. As consciousness, as it were, sinks down into its own depths and there meets with something higher that [296] is the ground of human life and its power of life, it finds again in itself the religious relation; and since this has been found by way of cognition, the human spirit can live in it without falling into discord with itself and giving itself up, and without denying a fundamental activity of its essence by bringing knowledge as a sacrifice to faith. As moral consciousness matures, it becomes religious consciousness, no longer “religionless morality”. But this religious, which has its germ in the Human as such, is something essentially other than the content of positive religion; it is the universally, ideally religious. Therefore, at the same time as it is sought, precisely the confessional differences, indeed even the differences between the various historical religions, become vanishing, and

they must become so, precisely because it is the *universally* Human in *religious* form that one seeks to draw forth and unfold. In our days the Protestant and the Catholic, the Christian and the Jew, indeed the Christian and the Hindu who is touched by the breath of life of humanity, can meet in a faith that is essentially one, even if they have not given this common faith a common expression. And this striving of the age toward the religious in its liberation from the historical forms — a striving that often lacks only full clarity and courage to acknowledge itself, — can also be recognized as hidden beneath the most diverse, apparently wholly heterogeneous phenomena. It is hidden, as if stunted and unclear, beneath the attempt of half-speculative, half-Christian theology at a halfway rationalizing of dogma, at a halfway humanizing of the Christian, by means of a halfway giving-up of what is Christian in principle. — It is hidden in the attempt of ordinary theology to go behind the historical, confessional expressions of Christianity in order to find an original, ideal Christianity that is supposed to have hovered before the Founder's thought but never to have found a corresponding expression in actuality; for this ideal, unhistorical Christianity becomes in actuality only an expression of the abstractly universal element in the positive religions, in which they coincide with rational faith. — It is present, as if hiddenly at work, in the general conception of the positive [297] forms of religion that have come into being in our days. Even those who feel no rest in the older positive religions nevertheless regard the new ones with indifference or mistrust. The relation of the consciousness of our time to positive religion becomes the same as its relation to miracle. Like miracle, positive religion is regarded as something past; even if one does not deny its reality altogether, one conceives it as something whose coming-to-be belongs only to the past, has actuality only there, not in the present. But this conception is only the indirect denial of its reality altogether. — And finally that striving can also be hidden beneath the very adherence to the absurd positive forms of religion that our time has created; for frequently it is precisely an unclear seeking after the free religious that brings people to cast away the earlier positive forms, if only to find a temporary rest in a new positive religion.

The universally religious, to which the human consciousness in our time seeks its way back where it conceives itself more deeply and more completely, this "religion of humanity" that is the expression of the human essence's original ideal religious need, is clarified for consciousness through knowledge, through true, thoroughgoing cognition, through philosophical thought. But its relation to this cognition sets up no abiding distinction between the thinker's religion and the religion of the multitude. What is

grounded in the universally human must be capable of being formed in universally accessible forms of consciousness. Not in every form will the highest truth, which science brings to clarity, be accessible to all, but in one form or another it will be able to be so. “Monopolies of truth for the benefit of a single class of men would be wrongs [298] against all the others and real injuries to humanity” (Lichtenberg). Truth is what unites, what is to become the property of all, the medium of a common life. And the religious that has its root in the very ground of the human essence, the free and freed religious, will, just as it can become the property of all, satisfy the *whole* human spirit, satisfy the heart’s need too. It will be able to do so because it is the expression of the human essence itself, and because what is essential for religious consciousness has the ability to express itself in the most diverse forms according to the different stages of advancing human development.

For one who with an unbiased and comprehensive glance regards the religious movement in the consciousness of our time, a doubt will not easily arise about its real direction and about its goal for the future. But there lies in the historical circumstances under which the modern age has developed much that can make it explicable that the conception of the phenomena is so frequently confused, where uncertainty with regard to matters of principle works together with tendencies that obscure cognition. If the Christian had been the historically original, if it had come into a *new* world, and if it alone had been able to fill minds, then the conception of it could have been sure and easy: its real nature would, as it were, have forced itself upon cognition. But when Christianity came into the world, great periods of culture were already concluded, distinctive fundamental forms of the Human were already unfolded and exhausted. And Christianity, as what is foreign to the world, as what denies nature, has always been able to fill only one domain of the spirit, a single need, a single form of life, not to encompass the human essence in its whole compass. It has constantly had beside it another element, another principle of life, and since this developed simultaneously with Christianity’s existence and in interaction with the Christian, the confusion could easily arise that what had [299] only come into being at the same time as the Christian, partly in struggle against it, could be seen as having proceeded from the very principle of the Christian, as its rich unfolding. Thereby it became possible that what is called Christianity could become a phenomenon composed of such heterogeneous elements that those who stand within Christianity, but have received the basic content of their religious consciousness, its points of support, in this intergrowth with the foreign, could become uncertain about the

boundaries of the Christian against the Human, and that even the scientifically educated among the representatives of theology could regard a sharp separation, in principle, of the specifically Christian, whether it took place from a standpoint within or outside Christianity, as an “indefensible misunderstanding”, while they themselves put forward a conception of the Christian which, in seeking with a fragile dialectic to annex the Human, made the Christian into something blurred and unclear, and only concealed its lack of principle in the fog-clouds of phrases. —

We shall in what follows attempt to let representatives of the two conceptions of Christianity contending in our days have their say: of the one that posits the opposition between the Christian and the Human, and of the one that lets the former enclose the latter. And as we then, by way of history and of the development of concepts, ground our adherence to the conception that holds fast to the opposition, we shall set the Christianly religious beside the religiousness of humanity, which for us stands as the goal of religious consciousness. For this religiousness we shall then seek an expression, not exclusively in any single one of its spokesmen, but in what, in the various nuances in which it has taken shape, shows itself as something common and pervasive, as that in which its essential motives become clear.

Constans.

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The Christian and the Human as Opposites in the Consciousness of Our Time.

II.

In the conception of the Christian there stand in our day, within the domain of Christianity itself, two opposites facing each other, sharply distinguished in principle. The one has found its classic expression in our literature through an eminently gifted personality: through *Søren Kierkegaard*. For him the Christian stands as that which is unconditionally heterogeneous with everything worldly and with what is accessible to thought. The center of Christianity, the God-man, is the absolutely incomprehensible, the unconditioned paradox, to the acknowledgment of which in faith it is not the inferences of reason but the despair of the consciousness of sin that brings one. It is that to which one attains not through thought but in spite of thought and through a break with it. Faith grasps the incomprehensible, and in holding it fast with the passion of inwardness, it guards, precisely with all its strength and all its passion, its incomprehensibility against every attempt of thought to appropriate it. And just as Christian faith is conceived by Kierkegaard only as having issued from a break with thought, so too the Christian life [434] that springs forth from this faith is conceived as having issued from a break with the world. Christianity is the religion of suffering; its commandment is to die away from the world; only through this death does it show the way to life. And this negative relation to the world is not restricted to a single time, as, for example, to Christianity's first historical appearance. As little as the unconditioned paradox of faith ever becomes more comprehensible with time, so little does the life that rests in it ever become homogeneous with the life of the world. Christianity, which, by demanding death, the death of selfhood, and the renunciation of everything worldly outside and within the individual, awakens the resistance of selfishness and worldliness, must constantly stand equally hostile over against "the world"; it must at all times be mocked, reviled, hated, persecuted. And where history shows a peaceful relation, that is precisely the sign that Christianity has lost its peculiar character, that it has been corrupted by an admixture with the heterogeneous, that it has lowered the ideal demand, has denied itself. In the Christendom of our time Kierkegaard therefore does not recognize Christianity; he sees in it only a deception carried on through many centuries and carefully veiled; in the church protected by the state he sees only a caricature of Christianity, whose preachers live off Christ instead of living for him. He raises, doubting, the question whether Christianity still exists on

earth, and as, with his ideal of the Christian before his eyes, he goes back through the history of the church right to its first age, he carries that doubt with him right up to it and asks gloomily: have there ever really been Christians? has the ideal demand of Christianity ever been fully realized? And this question is consistent; for can the religion whose principle is *not* to live in the world, to be dead to the world, really find its perfect expression in the world?

In this conception of the Christian there is expressed at once the sharpest opposition to the Christianity of “Christendom” and to the Human. In opposition to the concept of a Christendom in which the individual is, as it were, a Christian by birth and continues to be one by virtue of the connection with something objectively subsisting, Kierkegaard [435] accentuates the concept of “the single individual”. Face to face he would set the individual, as a “single individual”, with God, with the infinite demand of the religious, in order to let the decision take place in the depth of inwardness, in the meeting where the divine and the human touch in the innermost of the self. Every objective way to the God-relation he cuts off, not only the one that goes through objective thought, but also the one that goes through the church. The subjective, personal relation to the truth becomes, according to man’s conditions of existence, the one true relation: in infinite concern for himself, in the concern that the consciousness of sin awakens, the individual is, in the subjectivity-relation of faith, which is the relation of an infinite passionate interest, as a single individual to win the relation to the divine as it is revealed as “the god in time”, as the paradox that for thought is the absurd, for faith the infinitely certain, which in every moment, in fear and trembling, is won out of objective uncertainty.

“The single individual” is the point of departure, and had to be so for one who saw in “Christendom” a corruption that comes to light at once in the mixing of the Christian and the worldly and in the individual’s absorption into the ecclesiastical community, the impersonal universal. But “the single individual” is not, as was quite recently asserted through a conspicuous misunderstanding, the end point for Kierkegaard. First the illusion had to be broken, and it had to be made clear to the individual that its way to God can go only through the narrow pass of inwardness, not along the highroad of the objective; only on this condition could the upheaval in souls on which Kierkegaard staked his life become actuality. But once the “single individuals” had each for himself entered into the true God-relation, the concept of the congregation, of the community, regained its validity, because the single individuals met in the same eternal goal. There came to be a communal relation for the single individuals, but in such a way that God was the middle term between the single individual and the community, not the community the [436]

middle term between the single individual and God. This relation is so clearly stated in Kierkegaard's writings that only an urge to parade a superiority by getting Kierkegaard's standpoint subordinated as a moment in a higher ethical-Christian-ecclesiastical-human one can explain the misunderstanding that ascribes to Kierkegaard another conception.

But the life that is set as a task for the single individual while he stands alone face to face with God, and while he finds in his God-relation the relation to the other individuals, becomes a life that sharply separates itself from the Human. What sustains it is that which is inaccessible to thought: the unconditioned paradox, that which for thought is the absurd. But the paradox, which conflicts with all the laws and forms of thought in that it asserts the union of God and the individual human being in the person of Christ, the coming into being of the eternal in a moment of time, is for the believer the highest truth. The true then judges that which conflicts with it as the untrue, and there remains in the spirit no place for a life of thought; there remains no validity, not even a relative one, for thought. The paradox has rightly been designated "the miracle in the world of thought", and it has rightly been emphasized that, just as the miracle in the world of nature cancels the concept of nature and of natural law, so the miracle in the world of thought must overturn the laws of thought and let all the certainty of knowledge dissolve into doubt. The demand on the believing individual would consistently have to be "that in its life of thought it is to cast away all the world's content of actuality merely in order to be with the paradox of the consciousness of sin in the paradoxical God-relation." This must become the demand, because the paradox contradicts not merely a single form of human thought but *all* human thought; because here there is not a conflict between two forms of the rational, but between the rational in its entirety and the antirational. The absurd, Kierkegaard's categorical determination for the paradox, excludes *all* thought.*)

[437] But just as the believer's life, as Kierkegaard conceives it, forms the opposite of the human life by denying thought, which expresses an essential determination in the human, so it comes into conflict with that life because it consistently cannot make room for the concretely moral, for all those forms of an ethical life that rest on a natural ground in the human.

According to Kierkegaard's conception the religious relation becomes not merely the highest relation, to which the ethical relation points, in pointing beyond itself, but it becomes the absolute relation in the sense that it cannot "exhaust itself or become concrete" in the ethical relative relations. It becomes the absolute relation, then, in the sense that it lays claim for itself to all of man's strength and lays claim to it in every

*) Cf. Nielsen: Religionsfilosofi, pp. 8, 34, 301 ff., and elsewhere.

moment; for only as I always, in every moment, “relate myself absolutely to the absolute” do I preserve the relation according to its essential determinacy. But then no strength remains over for the ethical relations: they must vanish before the absolute, the infinite, precisely because they fall outside it; just as the finite strength of the creature must vanish when it is placed over against the infinite might of omnipotence. Therefore the demand is also made of man that, for the sake of the infinite religious relation, he be able to renounce *all* the ethical relations. The religious does not become the soul in the ethical, does not permeate the ethical relations in such a way that, in raising them up into a higher sphere of infinity, it itself gains living actuality through them; rather it stands over against them as the infinite that consumes the finite, as the divine that brings death to the human whose eye has seen it. In Christianity’s demand to die away, to hate one’s natural life, it is implied that the content of natural existence vanishes as a nothing in its unconditioned opposition to the eternal truth, and with this natural foundation there vanishes the condition for that unfolding of the ethical through which alone it can gain actuality. The more decidedly Kierkegaard stamps his standpoint in the course of his opposition to the unprincipledness of the established order, the more decidedly this [438] consequence too comes forward. In the polemic against marriage in “The Moment” the consequence is stated undisguisedly.

The contrast to the Kierkegaardian conception of the Christian is formed, now, by the one that extends the name of the Christian to all those forms of spiritual life that have developed simultaneously with and under the influence of Christianity. It sees Christianity not as the opposite of the spiritual life of our time but as its animating principle; it speaks of a Christian state, a Christian ethics, a Christian art, a Christian science; in a word: it applies the name of Christianity to all forms of the Human; it calls the world in which Christianity is like a foreign guest a Christian world. The sharp distinction between the principle of Christianity and that of the world it allows, although it constantly points to the apostolic as the orienting, to have been justified only in Christianity’s first age, in which the struggle with the forms of the old world had to lead to an exclusive relation. From the moment when Christianity became victorious, on the other hand, its task was not to be to separate itself from the world, to die away from it, but to permeate it; its divine power is to show itself precisely in this, that it has been able to do so, and its capacity, as principle of life, to permeate the heterogeneous is sought in this, that Christianity is a new creation, which acts back in an elevating, “potentiating” way on nature and on the spiritual forces and laws. Not flight from the

world but immersion in it, not struggle against it but peace with it and dominion over it then becomes Christianity's goal, which in the Christian state is reached in the way in which it can be reached under the conditions of finitude, and the state's recognition of the Christian, its favoring of it in the way of worldly goods, becomes a new proof that the human Christianity, reconciled with the world, is the true one. And the same recognition [439] is also rendered to Christianity by reason. Even if the unregenerate, darkened reason does not comprehend the mysteries of Christianity, the believing reason, potentiated by the new principle of life, is nonetheless able to penetrate into their depths, and even if it does not attain logical or mathematical clarity, it can nonetheless explore the connection of the articles of faith, and thereby their ground, and develop a science of faith that is the summit and norm of all science. Christian philosophy rises, as thought borrows wings from imagination, to descry in the God of Christianity an eternal nature, cleansed of all the imperfection of the grosser nature defiled by man's sin. It sees in this eternal nature in God the possibility of asserting the relative justification of the natural in the human, the possibility of a reconciliation of the oppositions in human life. And in the union of the divine with the human in Christ it sees the highest expression of the reconciliation that thought demands: between the infinite spirit and the finite, between the creator and the created, spiritual-natural existence. Thus Christianity is seen as reconciled with the world and with thought, as their new, consummating principle of life.

For this conception the Kierkegaardian one becomes a damnable one-sidedness, just as much as the "emancipated" reason's assertion of the Human as the true in its distinction from the Christian. In place of distinction there steps everywhere mediation; the rich "higher unity" asserts itself with dignified superiority over against the poor one-sidednesses; the Human is condescendingly taken up as a serving moment, and with rhetorical pathos the triumphs of Christianity are proclaimed.

To a fleeting glance all this can be very beautiful to behold, and the need for a reconciliation won without the struggle of the will and the exertion of thought, a need so widely spread, makes it psychologically easy to explain that such a theory of leveling finds approval with the great multitude, which needs not clarity but reassurance, and which more readily receives the smooth phrase than the sharp thought. If one looks a little more closely at the matter, however, one discovers without difficulty that the [440] smooth phrase only binds together loosely stitched oppositions, that the higher, richer unity that is supposed to have been won has been procured only by a very poor method, stereotypically repeated everywhere, which can yield as its result only semblance, not actuality, phrases, not concepts. The stereotyped method is simply this: one takes

the opposites one wants to bring together and joins them in one sentence as subject and predicate, and then one sends the phrase so formed out into the world with the endorsement that it “must be thought”, which presumably is to be understood rather like the “may be printed” (*imprimatur*) that the censor in his day put on the books that were sent out into the world. At any rate one cannot well attain to more than a permission to think the phrase; an actual thinking of it becomes a sheer impossibility. Since both opposites find their expression in the phrase, these expressions of theirs must, as it were, neutralize each other: the predicate that is joined to the heterogeneous subject must, instead of determining the subject, rob it of its content and leave behind for consciousness only an indeterminate, vague representation, a representation of a nothing; and when the opposites in their determinacy then press forward again to consciousness, the contradiction and the discord are there anew, and the unity must vanish, unless consciousness can be lulled into a gentle slumber by the monotonous music of the phrase. A single example will suffice to illustrate what has been said. The opposition between positive religion and philosophy in the conception of the relation of the divine to the being of existence finds its pregnant expression in the opposition between the representation of creation and the concept of a world-unfolding, a cosmogony. For religion existence is a work of the incomprehensible arbitrariness of a creating omnipotence; for philosophy existence has being in virtue of the very eternal necessity of the essence of the divine; it is an unfolding of the essential determinations of the divine itself. Here sharp opposites, irreconcilable as it would seem, stand over against each other; but that method unites them easily — in a phrase that “must be thought”. For first the representation of creation is rationalized by the concept of cosmogony: it is not to be a God determined as nature- [441] less spirit, who by an incomprehensible act of omnipotence produces out of nothing an existence that, as material, has no point of attachment in the essence of the divine and therefore cannot be comprehended as its effect. It is to be a God who has a nature within him, who creates out of free necessity, and it is to lie in the concept of creation that God produces not something dead but something living, that he produces a creature that at the same time produces and develops itself in a given independence. Therefore creation *must be thought* to ground cosmogony, or the world’s self-development, its genesis. But when this step toward naturalism has been taken, when that which for the religious consciousness makes creation creation has been effaced, then the foot is cautiously drawn back, and the text continues: “The world’s cosmogonic or natural beginning is the relative, the finite one, which is therefore also split into sporadic multiplicity. All organization forms itself sporadically, and viewed from the cosmogonic or the natural

standpoint the world can be said to have countless beginnings, to begin from infinitely many seeds of life, which, insofar as the natural standpoint is exclusively held fast, have their common unity only in chaos. But the infinitely many natural beginnings are all grounded in the one creative, supernatural beginning, in the divine Logos-will, which encloses within itself the wellspring of life and of light and out of its spiritual depth releases the whole multiplicity of living forces to self-movement.” So: creation was cosmogonic, the supernatural natural, and now in return cosmogony becomes creation, the natural supernatural. Thus the unity must be thought; indeed, it would be an indefensible one-sidedness to separate the determinations. But just as the creation that was cosmogonic lost, precisely through this predicate, that which was to make it creation, so now the cosmogony which, as *grounded* in creation, itself becomes creation — in that the relative, natural beginning vanishes in the supernatural, the material in [442] the “spiritual depth” — loses in return precisely that which makes it cosmogony. We are then left with two empty representations, two names without any content, which we are free to think, if indeed we can think anything by what is contentless; and if we cannot, and, so as not to let our thought lose itself in the empty, we call back the content of the concepts and then try to use the permission to think their unity, the opposites split apart again. Then creation again stands against cosmogony, arbitrariness against necessity, imagination’s picture of nature in God’s “spiritual depth” against real, actual, material nature, the miracle against the lawful development of nature valid in its essence, the supernatural against the natural. And the contradiction is not removed by such logogriphs as that God “restricts” his omnipotence but “does not give it away”, that he “produces a creature” that at the same time “produces itself”, a creature that possesses a “given independence”. The unity evaporates in the empty turns of phrase: both opposites are distorted, and sense can be brought into the phrases only if, in place of the half rational, the half natural, one puts the wholly antirational, the wholly supranaturalist, takes what belongs to the one opposite as a mere turn of phrase that is not meant to signify anything further, and lays all the emphasis on what belongs to the other. But then mediation has been given up, and we have returned to the conception that was condemned as a one-sidedness.

We could restrict ourselves to demonstrating the frailty of the method of the theory of mediation; but in order to provide complete material for the judgment on the *Juste-milieu* theory, we shall also take the path of history and of the development of concepts, in

order along it to secure for ourselves the understanding of the Christian, the conception of its essential and principled relation to the Human.

When we would find the historical presuppositions for the coming into being of Christianity, they are to be sought essentially in the development of the Greek and of the Jewish spirit. From different points of departure these national spirits, the representatives [443] of the Aryan and of the Semitic stock, strive toward one goal of development, and as they meet, the conditions are given for the coming into being of Christianity. Whatever may have been taken up into it from other, oriental, elements has in any case come to it through the Greek or the Jewish.

If we then consider first the development of the *Greek* spirit, what becomes of essential significance here is the breaking forth of dualism in Greek thought and view of life. The Greek people, the representative of the life of beauty in world history, had found its highest expression for the intuition of existence in the conception of it as a cosmos, as a world-artwork; it had found its highest expression for the ideal human life in the conception of it as a moral artwork, as a harmonious forming of the natural side in man by reason. The intuition of beauty was thus for the Greeks the highest; it poured itself like a radiance over existence and human life, which was seen as resting in the repose of harmony. And in the relation to the gods the same intuition of beauty stepped into the foreground. When a Greek stood before Fidas's image of the Olympian Zeus or of Pallas Athene, then his devotion was this: to let the harmony of beauty of the ideal image sink down over the soul, to bring stillness, repose and harmony into its desire and passion, to let all pain be soothed by the intuition of the divine, present beauty.

In this intuition of existence as beauty the dominion of the ideal is asserted; nature is subjected to the power of spirit. But the unity of spirit and nature in the harmony of beauty is nonetheless only a deceptive unity, deceptive because the artwork, in its immediate unity for intuition, joins two opposites: material and form, which stand as originally distinct, as not sprung from each other. When Greek thought reaches its full development, when it, as it were, unwraps the idea from the concealing veil of the sense-world and would comprehend its essence and its relation to the material that through it becomes a world-artwork, then the opposites separate for thought, and Greek [444] thought is not able to lead them back from the separation to a unity firmer and surer than the beauty-unity of harmony, because, as Greek thought, it has its limit in the intuition of beauty, is bound by it as by an insurmountable barrier. When Plato and Aristotle had brought Greek thought to its highest development, the dualism became visible, and the period of dissolution of the intuition of beauty begins. The consciousness

of the discord then leads first to attempts to see the whole of existence in the light of one of the opposites, and as these fail, it forces forth dualistic theories in which a *purely spiritual* God receives as his original opposite dark matter. But the dualistic distinction between spirit and nature, which tore apart the unity of beauty, had to contribute to calling forth skepticism; it had to give spirit, which was separated by a gaping chasm from the material, mistrust of its cognizing, of its theoretical faculty. And as this doubt was awakened, it brought decisive consequences with it. Whereas before, spirit, trusting securely in the power of its thought, had set that thought the highest goal and had found rest in its cognition of the divine and of existence, it now, in mistrust of thought, seeks other sources of truth, and it believes it finds them in the revelations of the hidden primal being through the positive religions or through demonic intermediate beings that connect the inaccessible deity with finite existence. And with mistrust of knowledge there had also to follow mistrust of man's moral strength. For the Greek, knowledge was man's essential determination; therefore that double mistrust was inseparable. Recourse was then had once more to the divine and to the intermediaries that connected it with man, in order to find aid toward what spirit could not reach by its own strength. Here too the way turned aside from philosophy to religion, and it led through purifications and cleansings, through flight from the sensuous to the divine being, from which every [445] determination of matter was excluded. The truth of existence thus lay in the purely spiritual, which rose to an infinite distance above the imperfection of matter, in which the germ of evil was sought; and the striving of the human spirit, which in the classical age of Greece had been satisfied within the whole of beauty that mirrored the Idea, now went out beyond the world to a world beyond, where all was spirit.

With this development in the life of the spirit there then followed a consequence that became of essential significance for posterity. As everything sensuous, everything natural, lost its significance, the natural barriers that separated the peoples also lost their significance; the particularist spirit that divided Greeks from barbarians, and that saw the true representative of the human only in the free-born Greek, was replaced by a universalism that recognized man *as* man, and asserted the human through the equality of men.

What was reached along this path gained strength from the external political conditions. The Roman world empire broke through the barriers of the nationalities, crushed the distinctive character of the peoples. Through suffering, spirits were led away from unsatisfying finitude to the beyond to which the religions pointed. But the popular religions and their individually distinct divine figures were already in the process of

melting together into an unclear unity, and this process of fusion was favored by the political unity. But while a Pantheon gathered the many gods and theology ordered their hosts, there rose above them a highest unity, lifted above all being and all thought and yet seen as the ground of all being and all thought; and for this invisible, purely spiritual divine being the many gods became serving demons, which led the yearning human spirit to its source, into which it sank down.

At the point to which we have followed the Greek spirit in its development, where it had exchanged the harmony of beauty for spiritualism, national particularism for universalism, it meets the *Jewish* spirit. This spirit had, in the time of the old Hebraism, rested securely in the present and this-worldly. The chosen people's contractual relation [446] to Jehovah, the law with its rewards and punishments, the sacrificial service and the cultus pointed to a childlike stage of development, where the spirit has its norm outside itself and its goal in something finite. Through the prophets the religious was inwardized; the tribulations of the time, which they interpreted from a religious standpoint, led out beyond the present to a hope for the future of a messianic kingdom; the first intimations of an immortality glimmered forth, and the narrow barriers of national consciousness began to open. After the exile we then find, in a certain sense, a regression, an unfree clinging to the traditional. But on the other hand we find preparations for a progressive development. We find such in the representation, formed under Persian influence, of a spirit-realm that is the archetype and truth of the earthly, in the representation of a supernatural Messiah, and in the doctrine of the resurrection. Finally, in the time immediately before the appearance of Christianity, we see what had been prepared come forth. Through contact with the Greek, the dualistic distinction now develops more definitely between a kingdom of the world and of matter, the kingdom of the evil powers, and a longingly awaited heavenly kingdom in a natureless actuality. The heavenly kingdom is striven toward through an ascetic flight from sensuousness, and faith in immortality takes the form of a hope for a complete liberation from earthly matter. Connected with this is a moral inwardness and a universal love of mankind, which in practice led to the condemnation of slavery (Essenes and Therapeutae). The representation of the Messiah is developed toward the supernatural.

In the conception of the divine in an abstractly spiritualistic manner; in the dualistic opposition between the spiritually divine and the material; in the human spirit's deep need to find peace and rest in a kingdom that is not of this world, by a dying away from everything natural, by flight from the world; in the distrust of being able, by its own power, to reach this goal — thus, at the beginning of the Christian era, the two

[447] national spirits meet: the spirit whose fundamental thought was *God*, and the one whose fundamental thought was *man*; and Christianity, which unites the two thoughts in the thought of the *God-man*, is determined in its basic character by its two essential factors.

Before we demonstrate this in the principal doctrines of Christianity, we will briefly see the *conceptual development of the positive religions* lead up to the point where the converging lines of development of the two national spirits have proved to meet.

As the human spirit in positive religion, driven by the need of its essence, seeks a relation to the infinite, this striving of it toward the infinite is realized only under conditions of finitude: through a progressive series of forms the religious consciousness must approach its ideal. The infinite that it seeks it finds first in nature: nature religion is the first form of positive religion, nature the first divine being. But the seeking spirit, which is not yet able to distinguish itself as something higher from nature, is not able either to distinguish nature from itself, in the way that it immediately senses itself as living, feeling and willing. Nature, before which man bows in worship, is not conceived as nature, but is humanized, is conceived as a personal, living, humanlike being. Thus the child sees external things as living and ensouled; thus it caresses them or is angry with them, because it ascribes will and thought to them. As the natural being that is worshipped is humanized, it becomes, through this very personification, in a certain sense a *supernatural* being. The natural object becomes as it were doubled: above the sensuous natural thing rises the thing's genius, its Fylgie, its Ferver, — to recall the expressions of the different religions. As the dryad separates from the tree and yet is the tree, as the naiad separates from the stream and yet is the stream, so the doubling takes place everywhere, in the particular and in the comprehensive. What in the doubling stands

[448] as it were behind the natural is then determined as something invisible, as something inaccessible to the senses — thus nature religion avoids the contradiction that is in it between representation and actuality, imagination and truth. The contradiction between the two objects into which the one natural object has divided is thereby to be canceled, in that the object that is religion's proper object is withdrawn from the immediate relation and becomes a being that is object only for faith, for the spirit. Herewith the conception of the divine in the religion of spirit is already intimated. And the religion of spirit replaces nature religion where human development has advanced so far that man, from a merely naturally determined being, has developed into a being that distinguishes itself from nature and as it were concentrates itself within itself. When man, through human social life, becomes a being that is determined by conscious laws of reason, when powers other than natural powers — political, moral powers — become the essential objects of

his feeling of dependence, then the world and nature no longer appear to him as God, but as a being determined by a divine understanding and a divine will and dependent on it. As man himself, by will and understanding, rises above nature and thus becomes a supranaturalistic being, his God at the same time also becomes a supranaturalistic being, no longer one with nature, but lord over nature; and he must finally, in order to be lord in the strict sense, become creator of nature. And the many gods that the religions of spirit receive from the nature religions must consistently melt together into a divine unity. The unity of human consciousness and spirit, which comprehends the whole multiplicity of the external world, is what leads to positing the unity of God.

Thus positive religion works its way up from the lowest stage of the nature religions to the highest of the religions of spirit, to the representation of the one, spiritual, creating God. But precisely when it reaches this point, the divine is conceived abstractly spiritualistically as the *natureless spiritual*. The organ of positive religion is not comprehending [449] thought, but representation and feeling. What it possesses concentrated in the rich inwardness of feeling it unfolds in representation; only in this unfolding does the content of feeling attain definiteness and clarity. But the distinctive mark of representation is that, from the sensuous intuition which it is to carry over into thought, it has retained a form of externality which brings it about that its content steps out into a finite distinction and is fixed for the inner eye in this distinction. Therefore the divine, the source and ground of all existence, is placed as divine personality above and outside this existence, determined as a *supernatural* being, in the sense that this supernatural forms the *opposition* to the positive determinations of nature. The *representational distinction* of the divine from nature as the supernatural includes the conception of it as the natureless spiritual: the transcendence of representation includes abstract spiritualism. But if the conception of the divine as the one, spiritual, creating God is the goal of the positive religions, then abstract spiritualism must be the hallmark of the highest of the positive religions; and the highest and concluding of them is Christianity. Only by carrying through, as consistently as is at all possible, an abstractly spiritualistic conception does Christianity attain a distinctive view of life. All antecedent stages, all preparations, are already given in the pre-Christian religions; only that one thing remains over for it.

In the basic Christian representations the abstractly spiritualistic is everywhere easy to demonstrate. It comes forth in the doctrine of *God* as the pure spirit who dwells in the light in which there is no darkness of matter. — It comes forth in the representation of a *creation out of nothing* by the almighty will: for thereby the created is posited as that which in its essence is a nothing, as that which has only from the arbitrariness

of omnipotence, by which it is upheld, a borrowed being that can at any moment be annihilated, as happens partially in the miracle, and for the whole of nature in the [450] destruction of the world, in which what was a nothing returns to the nothing from which it came, and lets only the spiritual remain. — It comes forth in the whole representation of the activity of the divine as a *miracle-working* activity, for in the miracle omnipotence works without anything real; it denies the being of the real and its validity. — It comes forth in the doctrine of the *human task of life*, which becomes this: to seek unity with God through Christ by deadness to the world, by the denial of the nature that “lies in wickedness”, which, when it asserts itself as nature in us, is determined as the sinful, and which therefore becomes that to which the spirit is to relate only negatively, so that it does not become a material that is to be formed, but one that is to be cast away, the Christian being bound to flee the relations of natural life, which for him have no significance but can only become defiling, because they cannot be placed in a positive relation to the abstractly spiritual (thus marriage, political life, property). — It comes forth in the conception of *life after death* corresponding to this conception of the task of life. What stands before consciousness as an ideal, but as an ideal it despairs of being able to reach in this existence, it transfers to a life beyond, where everything natural that still hinders and weighs down the spiritual shall have vanished, where the spirit shall be freed from every natural limitation, and where even the body in which imagination clothes the departed spirit in order to be able to intuit it shall be a “spiritual body”. — It comes forth finally in the very doctrine of the *God-man*, precisely at that central point of Christianity where the divine is united with the human and, through the human, seems also to enter into a positive relation to the natural. For this semblance vanishes as soon as one considers that the life of the God-man is through and through a *miracle* and by the miracle is loosed from the usual natural conditions of human life: at birth and in [451] death, and at every point between them. The unity of God and man in the God-man becomes only the unity of God and the *natureless* human. —

Thus we have, by different paths, arrived at the same result: that the character of Christianity is natureless spirituality, which stamps its conception of the divine and of the human. The consideration of the historical presuppositions, of the conceptual development of the positive religions, and of the basic doctrines of Christianity itself has led us to one and the same conception and, by this agreement, given it certainty. And the feeble attempts that are made from the side of the theory of mediation to dispute this conception are of such a kind that they will not easily be able to make anyone doubtful. We will in passing — for that will be sufficient — cast a glance at one such attempt,

which is found in the collection of edifying reflections on ethical subjects that Bishop Martensen has recently published.

It begins with the postulate that Holy Scripture, on every one of its pages, is supposed to bear witness that God is not the natureless spirit. "Scripture knows only the living God. But the living God we (!) cannot think otherwise than in relation to an eternal nature subordinate to him." It then continues: "When Scripture speaks of God as an *indissoluble* life (Hebr. 7), we cannot think of this either except as the indissoluble unity of the oppositions of life, among which we know only the opposition between spirit and nature, the ethical and the physical." This exegesis, which by its mixture of childishness and hair-splitting recalls that of the rabbis, is as unfortunate as possible, as anyone can convince himself by reading through two lines at the passage cited (v. 16 f.). Christ is compared with Melchisedek, as the eternal high priest in contrast to the mortal high priest under the law of Moses. As the one who has no "beginning of days or end of life", as the one who "remains high priest continually", he is called high priest "after the power of an indissoluble life", and this expression is interpreted in what immediately follows, where it is said: "*for* thou art a priest *for ever* after the order of Melchisedek." Here there [452] is, then, quite simply an opposition between the life that can cease in death and that over which death has no power; but not a single turn of phrase points toward that higher unity of "the oppositions of life" which we "must think". One must be uncommonly destitute of reasons to resort to such an art of interpretation. Yet there is still one argument left that almost surpasses the previous ones. It is drawn from the fact that Scripture everywhere speaks of God in anthropomorphisms. "But the truth of religious anthropomorphism rests on the nature in God." "Living piety will not let itself be disputed out of the belief that God has eyes and ears, hands and feet, an arm that is not shortened; and it does not give up seeing his finger in the events of the world and in the life of the individual; for even though it is conscious of the figurative, the symbolic, and recognizes that everything must be removed that belongs only to created limitation, it nevertheless continues to hold fast that there must be a real counterpart to all this in God; which in other words means that God must have organs of revelation, instruments — an organism." — So: the anthropomorphic is to be image, symbol, hence *not* express actuality; but we are nevertheless to demand a *real* counterpart, and while we remove everything that could give these determinations content, we are to ascribe to God a body, an organism. It is the old method characterized above: one gives with one hand and takes with the other. The anthropomorphic is to be non-real and yet real, non-literal and yet literal, and that in order to support a poor, tottering, half-speculative theory that fables about "physical

all-possibilities” in God, about a “relative nothing” that is to be the same as the “eternal, physical possibilities”, about “physical but *supernatural* powers”, about a matter that differs from nature by having “stepped out (how?) of connection with the spirit”, and the like. It is characteristic that the herald of the theory must himself concede that “no
 [453] concrete comprehension” of it can take place. Indeed! the empty phrases dissolve of themselves into a nothing that is not a “relative” but an altogether complete “absolute” one, and it is by an “indefensible misunderstanding” that the authors of Holy Scripture are charged with professing such a theory. What would the author of the Gospel of John say to the interpretation cited of “the figurative language of Scripture?”

If we hold fast to the conception of Christianity as that whose hallmark is natureless spirituality, then the historically given phenomenon that meets us under the name of Christianity becomes easily explicable to us. We understand not only Christianity in its struggle with the world, in its classical figures, in the forms of life in which it has sharply stamped its distinctive essence; but we also understand the forms in which the Christian is mixed with its opposite. We understand without the least difficulty how the nature-denying and world-denying religion — as it (contrary to the hope of the first Christian age for Christ’s imminent return) was to go on existing in the alien world, as it was to be proclaimed in this world, as it was to defend itself against the attacks from it, and as it was to be unfolded in consciousness — had to exchange its originally merely negative relation to nature, to the natural faculties and powers (naturally determined thought included), and to the concrete forms of the life of the world, for a forced connection with what it denied, which was taken up as means for the Christian. Thus we explain what has been called a Christian science, a Christian art, a Christian morality, a Christian state. But we understand at the same time that the forced factual recognition of what was denied in principle could never become a full and true recognition, and that therefore the forced connection could not become a real union; for what was taken up remained,
 [454] as mere means, without essential connection with the Christian. Thus too the relation shows itself everywhere where the Christian becomes conscious of itself, as we have demonstrated above (no. 4, p. 291) with regard to “Christian” philosophy.

But while the phenomenon, from this standpoint which posits the opposition between the Christian and the Human, becomes easily explicable, the mediation that speculative theory attempts on the basis of the conception, characterized above, of Christianity’s relation to the natural, runs up against insoluble difficulties. If the mediation is taken really seriously, then Christianity, which clearly and distinctly proclaims itself as a new

creation, that is, as an absolutely new beginning, and which for centuries has been conceived as such by its confessors, becomes something purely superfluous, since what it is supposed to be in unity with the Human has already been given prior to Christianity. And all the great classical figures throughout the whole Christian era must then be conceived as one-sided, limited individualities to whom the proper truth of Christianity has not dawned. — If restrictions are made and reservations taken, so that the mediation becomes only half — and as a rule speculative theology ventures to go only so far when it has to pronounce on principles — then both the Human and the Christian are distorted, and both become meaningless. The Human is distorted and becomes meaningless in that, despite all appreciative phrases, it receives only a sham actuality and a sham significance. The Christian is distorted in that the elements it takes into itself from what is alien, although they are as it were instantly sublimated, nevertheless cast a tinge over the Christian that robs it of its specific distinctiveness, make it something without principle and therefore meaningless.

But if the conception of the Christian as natureless spirituality stands firm, then it also stands firm that there must continue to be an opposition between it and the Human, despite the significance the Christian may have had for the development and [455] purification of the latter. The Christian era has been the purgatory of the human spirit, the time of purification of the Human. Natureless, abstract spirituality with its negative infinity has as it were burned sensuousness and finitude out of the human essence, and thereby made it possible for the spirit, as it immersed itself in the richness of its essence, to give this richness the form of an infinity full of content, and thus to be able to live an eternal life in the reconciliation of the spirit within actuality. It has been able to break down the barriers that separated the peoples from one another, and to strengthen the consciousness of a humanity, a consciousness which antiquity had already reached. And Christianity, by powerfully reminding the human spirit that human life first finds its truth in the relation to God, has given it the impulse as it were to deepen all the human relations of moral life in the relation to God, to make them all religious relations. But the view of life of natureless spirituality includes consequences against which the human view of life must defend itself. As the natural foundation of human life becomes a nothing, and more precisely such a nothing as, when it asserts itself as a something, as an actuality, is seen as evil, then the foundation of concrete moral life, of all the forms of life which, like marriage, society, the state, rest on a natural basis, is taken away: only the ascetic flight from the world, only a renunciation of the whole actual content of moral life

remains. And when nature vanishes from the essence of the merely spiritual God, then God's activity in the nature posited by an incomprehensible act of omnipotence becomes the miracle-working activity that leaves no room for laws of nature; and with the laws of nature fall the laws of thought, and the validity of thought vanishes. Everywhere thought meets the miracle as the higher truth, and at the central point of Christianity, in the doctrine of the God-man, of the unity of the eternal, all-embracing divine with the particular human being existing under the limitation of the conditions of finitude, it [456] meets the miracle in its most pregnant form, and it can only assert itself and the human essence, whose fundamental determination it is, by separating itself from what must annihilate it. —

But as the separation thus comes forth between the human consciousness and the religion which, as the highest and concluding form of the historically given positive religions, is the legitimate representative of positive religion, the human consciousness does not turn away from the religious in its ideal form, freed from the limitation of the positive; rather it finds this ideal religious as it immerses itself in itself, as it penetrates to the ground of the human essence, to the point where this essence is bound indissolubly to its divine origin. How this relation between the Human and the ideally religious is to be determined more precisely, we shall seek to show in a following section, which will conclude these developments.

Constans.

The Christian and the Human as Opposites in the Consciousness of Our Time.

III.

When, in the many forms under which the human view of life — in its more clearly or more dimly conscious opposition to the Christian — has given itself expression since the beginning of modern times, we seek what is common and pervasive, what must be posited as the essentially determining factor, we shall find it in two main points. The one is the striving of the human orientation of life to assert the *undisturbed, harmonious unity in the human essence*; the other is its striving to assert *the ethical in its concretion*, to give the moral life a content of actuality rich enough to fill out *the whole* of human life. But these two main points stand, as will readily appear, in the closest inner connection.

Whereas the Christian view of life — by denying the validity and essentiality of the natural, and by placing truth in that which for thought was the unappropriable, that which conflicted with all the laws of cognition — had set a rupture in the human essence, a rupture that was infinitely sharpened when the doctrine of original sin posited human nature as disturbed and corrupted, the human view of life asserts unity in the *double* sense of a unity between the natural side and the spiritual side in man, and of a unity, [493] a harmony, between knowledge and faith, between cognition and will, between the theoretical and the practical. The nature which the medieval spirit had denied, from which it shrank back in dread, while the imagination was irresistibly lured by what it dreaded — *that* was restored to its rights once more at the beginning of the new age. As the human spirit sought into itself in order to find itself in its freedom and independence, it could no longer remain blind to the indissoluble bond that bound it to nature, to the fullness of life it drew from nature. The anxious hovering between fear and allurements was replaced by enthusiastic devotion. It was as if the Godhead had once more returned to the forsaken nature, which was now again seen in essential connection with its author, which in its beauty again became an object of the spirit's admiration, and in its essentiality and its grounding in law again became a source of cognition for the spirit. This orientation toward nature runs through the whole of modern times. We find it in the Renaissance's enthusiastic deification of the natural universe; we find it in empirical science's devotion to nature; we find it in the eighteenth century's rapture over nature and in its demand for naturalness in education and in life; we find it in our century in the renewal and spread of materialism, theoretical and practical, in the mighty

development of the natural sciences, in philosophy's endeavor to see the unconscious and conscious mental life in man as a unity and to give the divine a natural content; indeed, we find it even in philosophizing theology's groping attempts to get an imaginative picture of nature into the supernatural God. But nature, once more acknowledged in its essentiality, is then, as natural determinateness in the human, seen in unity with the spiritual. Organic life unfolds into a spiritual life, into a life of consciousness; from our natural side, through the organic conditions, our cognition receives its content; from our life of drives the life of will receives its material. The natural in us becomes no longer that which is only to be denied, that from which our will is to die away in order to live a purely spiritual life; it becomes again, as in Greek antiquity, that which is to be formed and harmonized by the will that, through cognition of our essence and its fundamental relations, has gained clarity about its task, and that realizes the demand of true cognition. In one-sided forms this acknowledgment of the natural in us emerges in those psychological, ethical and social theories that let our determinateness by drives become the supreme ruling power, that let it govern our individual development and the ordering of social relations. But what asserts itself here in a one-sided way receives its true form where an original lawfulness in our *spiritual* essence is acknowledged, according to which the natural determinations in us are ordered and formed, and under which they bow in service while being acknowledged in their legitimacy.

When the unity of the *natural side* and the *spiritual side* in us is asserted, the unity between *knowledge* and *faith*, between cognition and will, is asserted as well. It is the denial of nature that robs thought of its foothold; it is the miracle, in which the actuality of the real is annihilated in favor of the incomprehensible working of supernatural omnipotence, that sets thought an insurmountable barrier and robs its laws of their truth. Where faith, as in positive religion, is faith in the wonder-working God, in the God before whose will the laws of nature vanish, at whose command nature itself vanishes, just as it came into being at that command: *there* faith and knowledge must form irreconcilable opposites; and since faith, as the organ of the higher truth, condemns knowledge to submission, to self-surrender, a fundamental form of the human spirit, an essential determination in it, is here denied. A rupture then enters the essence, an inner discord; for the essential that is to be denied cannot, precisely as essential, be annihilated. The relation can be otherwise when the natural is asserted in its truth, when nature is no longer held up over the abyss of nothingness by an omnipotence hovering above it, but when it, as bearing the life of the divine within itself, rests in its laws determined by its essence. Here the essence and working of the divine does not become something from

which thought is thrown back, and which can be grasped only by a faith that denies thought: it becomes a content for the knowledge that, following the demand lying in the human essence, ventures out confidently from the finite in its multiplicity and limitation to the infinite. And when knowledge and faith no longer stand as opposites, when the human spirit finds rest in the content of its cognition, there comes to be a harmony between cognition and action as well. The faith that stood against knowledge also gave the will a law opposed to the law of knowledge. Not in the demand of the human essence but in the command of a supernatural, incomprehensible will was the norm of action sought, where the task of action was not the purely negative one: to flee the natural. But when faith and knowledge are in harmony, then the demand of knowledge, which expresses the law of the human essence, the human essence's own demand, is also seen as the one valid demand upon the will; then the same undivided human essence that comes to clarity about itself in its cognition is seen as expressing itself, in agreement with itself, in conscious action. The theoretical and the practical are then seen in harmony: one essence unfolds through both. The spirit does not waver between a double principle, a double law; it is not gnawed by doubt about the truth of its cognition and the validity of its action: in the harmony it has its assurance; it has rest in unity with itself. —

As the *second* main motive in the human orientation of life we determined *the assertion of the ethical in its concretion*, of the moral life's content of *actuality*. Within the religion whose character was abstract, nature-denying spirituality, the ethical task of life could consistently become only a dying away from everything natural, an ascetic flight from the world in order to find rest in a purely spiritual life. The ideal had to become a life beyond, where all natural barriers had vanished, where everything burdensome and defiling in the nature-determined earthly existence had been removed. As long as man [496] lived under the conditions of earthly life, he could not but feel constantly, in his bondage to the natural, a restraining bond and a seed of discord within himself. The promptings of drive in the natural, through which nature asserted itself as a power in us, were felt as temptation and defilement, and the gaze turned longingly toward the future in which the spirit would live freed from this restraint. The asceticism of Christian antiquity and of the Middle Ages, monastic life and the hermits' flight from the world, were not one-sidednesses and exaggerations but consistent expressions of the spirit of the religion. Where the natural has lost its validity, where natureless spirit is the highest, *there* no other life can consistently be lived than one that is at every moment a dying away from the world. For the concrete forms of moral life there can be no room; their validity is conditioned by the validity of the natural foundation in us. All moral relations and all

moral forms of society point back, directly or indirectly, to this natural principle; they fall when it is denied. But the denial of it is for man a self-contradiction, because the human essence comprises the spiritual and the natural in inseparable unity. The force by which nature in us is to be subdued can come only from the natural ground itself in us, which is an abiding constituent of our essence: in the very negation of the natural, the natural affirms itself. The life of natureless spirituality therefore remains always only an attempt, which can be repeated again and again but never carried through, because that which is to be killed draws strength, in the very struggle, from the hidden ground. Therefore there is anxiety and unrest in this life, and it can be removed only when everything that belongs to the human essence is acknowledged, when this essence in its whole compass becomes the object of ethical action, when the task becomes the free realization of the human essence in its completeness, when *the whole* of life in its fullness of actuality is drawn in under the ethical.

[497] A striving toward this we also find, in many forms, less perfect and more perfect, throughout the whole of modern times. It is such a striving that emerges in the secular morality of civic life, which at the close of the Middle Ages emancipates itself from the ecclesiastical; it is this striving that emerges when religion is transformed into morals and in this transformation is often trivialized; it is this striving that runs through the philanthropic endeavors, through socialism's attempts to order social relations, through philosophy's endeavors to work ethics into actuality, to determine the principle of moral action in such a way that it aims at the whole richness of life.

But since the striving of the human orientation of life to assert moral life in its concrete actuality points back to the assertion of the validity of the natural, it thereby points back to what we singled out as the *first* motive: the assertion of the unity of the essence. It is the human essence that in its undivided unity harmoniously joins nature and spirit which can unfold itself in a concrete moral life. But the *unity* of the human essence is inseparable from the *undisturbedness* of the human essence; and since the striving of the human orientation of life aims at the double goal we have indicated, which lies on one and the same line, it is borne by faith in *the undisturbable good in human nature*, in human nature's *essential completeness* beneath all the imperfection that is inseparable from its development and its struggles. The firm conviction that the human essence cannot, through its deed — which, as the expression of the essence's activity, is an affirmation of the essence — transform, negate this essence, is a *pervasive* characteristic of all forms of the human view of life.

Since the human orientation of life separates itself in principle from positive religion, it cannot surprise us that it has frequently led to a separation from the religious altogether, to a “morality without religion”, indeed even to a passionate struggle against religion. [498] This, however, is neither a pervasive feature of the many forms of the human orientation of life, nor is it its natural consequence. In many of those forms, e.g. in socialist theories, we find a striving, however unclear, to give the view of life a religious completion, which here as a rule does not escape the fantastic. In other forms we find as it were a remnant of the positively religious, rationalized fragments of it. In some, finally, and these we regard as the properly consistent ones, we find from the beginning a striving to assert the unity of the Human and the religious in such a way that the latter is seen as most deeply grounded in the human essence and as determined in its form and its content by it. And it will also be easy to show that the cognition of man’s essence in its completeness must of necessity lead to the religious relation, and that it can be completed only in this.

If what is peculiar to human life, that which by a decisive difference distinguishes it from the lower forms of life, from plant life and animal life, is the determination of self-consciousness, the free knowledge of oneself and a knowledge of an infinite, then this points back to the infinity of the human essence. Only the being that has inner infinity can, in its relation to itself, be freed from the bondage to the particular that characterizes the animal’s self-sensation, which is never loosened from its momentary determinateness; only such a being can become conscious of itself in its unity and universality. And only the being that has inner infinity can have consciousness of an infinite, for this presupposes the infinity of consciousness, and this in turn the infinity of the being whose consciousness has this determination. But the spiritual being that has inner infinity can reach the goal of its unfolding, can find rest and satisfaction, only in a relation of infinity, in such a relation as that in which its determination of infinity is realized, as the being unfolds itself as a spiritual life-unity in which every original determinateness, every realized aptitude, is made a moment, drawn in under the conscious harmony of the being, a harmony realized through the activity of spirit that becomes the primitive expression of the self-conscious being: through cognition. And this relation of infinity, which is thus most immediately determined as a relation of the spirit *to itself*, cannot be thought through without its unfolding into a relation *to the divine*, into a *religious* relation. When we seek the *source* of the inner infinity in the human, when we think through the concept of self-consciousness, we arrive of necessity at the divine. The human self that becomes conscious of itself in its inner infinity can become conscious of itself only as a *derived* self, as a self that has its ground in something higher; and thus [499]

self-consciousness itself encloses a relation to the source of the human essence, to its divine ground, which is at the same time the ground of the whole of existence. Human self-consciousness is consummated only in God-consciousness. Because the human essence is grounded in the divine, it can, as a self-conscious being, come to realization only as this relation, by which the being has being, comes to be for its consciousness, and comes to be for it in such a way that the relation to God goes in unity with the self's relation to itself in self-consciousness.

Thus the inner connection of the religious relation with the essential determination of the human becomes clear. But in order that this relation shall acquire the character of *true* infinity, shall be freed from the limitation of finitude that constantly remains attached to the positive religions, with their deity separated from the world, personified, wonder-working, and with their separation of the religious relation from the human spirit's other essential relations of life, it must become a relation to a divine that is in truth an infinite, in that, as governing and encompassing existence, it is *indwelling* in it, and, as grounding the human spirit, it is *of one essence* with it. And it must become a relation that can in actuality permeate *all* the essential relations of the spirit, that can find its expression in the relations of *moral* life, and that, while raising them into a higher [500] sphere, itself gains fullness and actuality through them. Thus the religious relation comes to comprise *the whole* of human life, *all* the spirit's expressions of life; it becomes that in which the spirit at every moment finds rest and reconciliation: reconciliation in its own inner being through the harmony of the essence, and reconciliation with the ground of its existence.

The religious relation so determined, the *ideal* form of religiousness, the religion that can become *humanity's* religion, thus lies in man's essential determination as a necessary, inescapable demand; this relation, taken in its full, comprehensive significance, becomes the highest, completing form of realization of human life.

Only one determination still remains to be expressly stressed, lest what has been said here be misunderstood. The source of religion has been sought in the human essence; religion has been seen as having sprung from this essence, and from this point of view religion is seen as the work of the human spirit. But since the human essence is itself grounded in the divine, the origin of the source is to be sought deeper: in the being through which the human spirit has infinity as an inner essential determination, and the need for the realization of this infinity. From this point of view religion then becomes *the work of the Godhead*, a work of its inner revelation to the human spirit, i.e. of its *communication of essence* to it.

Through the conception of the *religious relation* in its ideal, universally human form, the conception of *the divine* to which the human orientation of life must consistently lead has been intimated. It cannot appropriate the positive religions' representation of the personal, wonder-working God. In the determination of personality, as it is made to count in the positive religions and by theology, it can see only a finitizing determination, an anthropomorphism that is transferred to God precisely in order to keep him separated, in representation, from the human and from existence, and to free his action from the law [501] of rational necessity and make room for the miracle. Instead of this determination of the divine it must seek another and higher one, which, while it expresses God's essence as *spirit*, frees it from confinement *in finitude*; which, while it designates God as the source of self-consciousnesses, frees him from the limitation and relative abstraction of the determination of self-consciousness. And by this determination it will then contradict the representation of the *wonder-working* God. The God who through the miracle breaks through the laws of nature and overturns those of thought, the thinking spirit cannot acknowledge without denying its essence, which it does not have from itself but from the Godhead. It must demand a God whose working does not contradict itself, as the working of the wonder-working God does, in that it cancels what it has itself posited and thus shows itself to be finite. It must demand a God whose *essence* finds its expression in the laws of reason that govern existence, and who therefore cannot break these laws.

This God, acting according to the rational necessity of his essence, it must then, in order to preserve his infinity, necessarily conceive as *indwelling* in the existence that has its ground in God, and, as indwelling in it, as uniting it in his unity and thus *ideally* distinguishing himself from existence as it is unfolded in the form of *real* being. As indwelling (immanent) in existence, as the one who permeates existence with his life and governs it from within, God must be determined as standing in a relation of *unity of essence* to real existence and to the human spirit. From the essence of the effect one must infer back to that of the cause, since the cause can only be the cause of that whose essential determinations it bears within itself. As author of nature God must not merely be a spiritual, an ideal being, but must have the determinations of reality in himself, must be *ideal-real* being. But as author of the nature that finds its completion in life and in spirit, God must be ideal-real being in the sense that ideality is the primitive determination, the fundamental determination in the divine, the one that comprehends [502] and explains the determination of reality. Through God's essence, then, nature in us is at once asserted in its essentiality and spirit in its ideal dominion. The oppositions of

existence point back to one principle as to their source; in the world of nature and in that of spirit one divine reason everywhere asserts itself, working according to eternal, inviolable laws, according to laws that have their guarantee in the very essence of the Godhead, whose expression they are. The lawfulness of existence is, as having proceeded from the indwelling eternal reason, an eternally valid lawfulness. — As the goal of existence and as that which determines finite spirits and becomes the goal and norm of their action, the divine is finally to be seen under *ethical* determinations, as the good; but this ethical determination of it, which definitively designates it as spirit is bound up in the closest way with its logical and physical determinations; it becomes only their fuller and richer expression, not a determination that frees the divine from the eternal laws of thought and, as theology would have it, makes room for miracle-working arbitrariness.

Through the conception of the human essence and its relation to the divine, a conception to which the human orientation of life must consistently lead, *the life-task for man* is determined. It can only be the free and conscious actualization of the human essence according to its complete determinateness. But this general formula for the life-task must receive a fuller expression. We can give it that by first seeing the human self as that which is an indivisible unity of spirit and nature, and as that in whose various fundamental activities the unity of the essence must express itself in accord with itself. The task then takes the more definite form that man is to develop his personality in the inner harmony of his fundamental activities and in inseparable unity of the spiritual and [503] the natural. Man thus receives his *essence* as a task, as the *concrete* unity in which the real natural foundation is not to be denied or cowed, but taken up into spirit and thoroughly formed by it, so that the will receives content and fullness from its natural ground, while in turn that which proceeds from the natural foundation receives a norm and a rule in the ethical demand, which proceeds from the essence of spirit with the stamp of the original (the *a priori*). This ethical demand, which bears the stamp of the unconditioned, and which originally comes forth in abstract form through the consciousness of an obligation as such, of an unconditionally valid “Thou shalt!”, is then, in order to be able to form thoroughly the natural foundation of the personality, to be unfolded, through the cognition of man’s essence, into a richness in which it corresponds to the richness in actuality of life and of action. The original consciousness of the good, of duty, is in the actuality of action to become a consciousness of this determinate good, of this determinate duty, and during this unfolding it is to retain its certainty, so that the whole of life through and through receives the stamp of the clear and conscious ethical.

We are pointed toward the same goal also when we see the general formula given above for the human life-task from another point of view. That man is to make his *essence* a task for himself according to its many-sided and complete determinateness means not only that he is to develop it in harmonious unity of spirit and nature and of the fundamental activities of spirit; but it means also that he is to develop it, not as isolated and atomistic, but as *a distinctive member in a whole of existence*, as incorporated into this existence and as subordinated to its principle. Only thus does the self develop according to its completeness; torn loose from the vital connection with the whole, it is precisely the incomplete, just as the single organ in an individual organism loses its integrity when it is separated from the whole that sustains it. But as the self becomes conscious of itself as incorporated into something more comprehensive and as subordinated to something higher, its *assertion of itself* in its distinctiveness becomes one with its *devotion to the* [504] *higher* that it is to serve; in other words: its self-assertion and self-unfolding receive the stamp of the *ethical*, its willing of itself becomes a willing of a higher demand, of the law of existence and of the will of the Godhead. Thus self-development loses every stamp of egoism; the unfolding of individual distinctiveness is taken into the service of the whole and of the principle; the life the individual lives for itself, it lives for the whole of humanity and for the divine. And as life at every point receives the stamp of the *ethical*, it receives at the same time, since the self everywhere in existence, in all the relative relations, meets the divine, the stamp of the *religious*; the whole of life becomes at once ethical and religious; the religious relation does not, as limited to particular times or to particular domains of life, separate itself off from the other essential relations of life, but comprehends, pervades and elevates all the others.

In this view of life, which rests on the conviction of the infinite worth of the human, in virtue of the indwelling of the divine in the universal human essence, undisturbed in its ground, and which leads to the recognition of the human in all its essential forms of appearance and to a universal love of humanity, of the human *as human*, the *Human* is thus in inward unity with the religious, which is seen as proceeding from the ground of the human essence and as gaining content through the ethical. It energetically points man toward an activity in the world of actuality, but toward an activity that in the work of actuality preserves the connection with the higher. By reminding at every moment of the solidarity of the human race, it reminds the single individual of the necessity, in order to solve his individual task, of working toward the solution of the social tasks. While the view of life that denies nature only gathers individuals in the work for their blessedness, but cannot unite them in a work for the earthly conditions of life for a life

[505] of spirit, the human view of life gathers them for this work, and in this very work it lets them work for their spiritual goal. Only through it can the foundation be laid for *an existence worthy of human beings for all*, because only it recognizes in the right relation the significance of the spiritual and of the natural, the right of the individual and the demand of society, self-regard and solidarity. —

This religious-human view of life does not, however, form for itself an idyllic picture of human life, a utopia, freed from the imperfections of actuality. It recognizes, over against the infinite demand of the moral, the distance of human life from its ideal, its imperfection, its guilt, its sinfulness. But in recognizing the painful distance between ideal and actuality, it does not give up faith in man, in his capacity to actualize the good, in giving *this* existence a content of eternity. When positive religion teaches the disturbance of the human essence by sin, a disturbance that only a divine miracle can remove, that religiousness of humanity maintains that the human *essence* cannot have been transformed by an act that has proceeded from the essence itself, any more than the essence of the organism is transformed because its integrity is suspended during illness. And just as little as it can concede that the human essence is disturbed by sin, just as little can it concede that nature should, through man, have been drawn into the disturbance. It cannot do so, because it sees the whole of existence as sustained by the indwelling principle.

When it recognizes evil, not merely as an imperfection, a lack, but as an opposition to the good, posited by man's will, it sees in the will that is active toward evil a will that must be broken in the struggle against the good, because it struggles against what is the very *essence* in the human, and must call forth a reaction from it. And it sees at the same time in this will, which has the semblance of false infinity, but which receives this semblance only from that which it struggles against and strives to displace, something [506] active, the direction of whose working can be so reversed that the infinitely strained energy actualized in the service of evil can become active for the good, acquire positive worth for it. Just as in the domain of the physical the forces can be converted into one another, yet lose nothing in this conversion, so here, in the transformation of force, the sum of force is to remain unchanged. But for the good to be able to be actualized in the individual, this view of life too must recognize that individuals need assistance. This assistance, however, it does not seek outside the existence in which the individual has its actuality; it seeks it in the other, supplementing individuals with whom the individual joins together in love, in mutual communication of essence, and, in the last instance, in the principle that is indwelling in the individual itself, and that joins it together with

the other individuals in the unity of the essence. As individuals enter into a relation of love to one another, it sees them as acting — at once purifying and supplementing — upon one another. The single individual becomes for the other a representative of man's universal, reason-determined essence, and as such it becomes for the individual, as it were, its personified, objectified conscience. As the one individual in that relation converts the other into a representative of the ideally human, it gains in it a determining norm, an ideal standard for its action, a corrective for it. And as the intuition of the universally human fuses with the intuition of the distinctiveness of personalities, of the distinctive forms in which the ethical is actualized in the different individuals, then the ethical distinctiveness, idealized by love, by the unconscious faith in man, includes not merely a corrective for what is deficient in the individual, but also an assurance of the ethical power in the human, and the individuals embraced by the relation of love show themselves also as supplementing one another. Thus the relation of love between human beings becomes an ethical source of life for the individuals. But through this relation of love, in which individuals are joined together in a spiritual unity, there is a pointing [507] toward the principle of this unity, toward the origin of individual spirits: the divine, and in it the assistance for the individual is in the last instance to be sought. The divine is, as the source of the individual spirit, that which works through it; it is that from which the human spirit has the determination of infinity that comes forth in its relation to itself, in its grasping of the good, and even in its egoistic willing of itself in opposition to the good. From this its ground the human spirit can never be separated, not even when it wills to be, for through the evil will itself the divine will works with the force of the essence, breaking and consuming the force of evil. In the breakthrough in which the good will breaks forth through the dissolution of evil, the divine is active; for the essence asserts itself in the breakthrough only by a working of *that* which is the ground of the essence. And in every struggle, in every wavering, the will can seek back to this ground, which reveals itself in the innermost of the self through the ethical demand, and it can find in it the completion of the lacking force through the full self-surrender by which the force of the eternal is won, as the individual freely loses itself to the eternal. Here there no longer remains a doubt about reconciliation as *there*, where the individual, trembling, knows itself dependent on the election or reprobation of an incomprehensible arbitrariness, on the "dreadful decree" of omnipotence (Calvin). Here there is certainty about reconciliation, because the individual finds the divine in itself as indwelling and becomes conscious of itself in its unity of essence with it. But as the last condition for the actualization of our life's goal thus becomes the divine working in us, we are pointed

back again to the religious as the consummation of our ethical life. In this unity of the ethical and the religious the former has its truth, the latter its actuality.

Since it has thus been shown that the human view of life can be completed only in [508] the religious, its normal relation to positive religion is thereby definitively determined. There must be an *opposition*, a clear and conscious opposition; but what is essential in the positive religions can, despite *it*, be preserved, and the positive, historical religions can be recognized in their significance for the attainment of the *ideal* stage of religiousness that has been designated as *the religion of humanity*. It is only one-sided forms of the human orientation of life that have fought in hostility against the positively religious, and that have conceived it as a mere distortion of the truth. As the human orientation of life gains a deeper cognition of man's essence and of his fundamental relations, it cannot avoid recognizing that it is precisely the same striving for the actualization of the human spirit's essence in a true relation of infinity, from which the ideal form of religiousness proceeds, that also has been what moved most deeply and what unfolded in the positive religions, even though that striving, in being realized under conditions of finitude, still shows itself in the positive religions as burdened with a limitation of finitude that comes forth in the conception of the divine, in the separation of the religious relation from the other essential human relations, in the forms of the human activities of spirit that come to unfolding on the stage of positive religion, and in the relation between them. Everywhere in the positive religions, therefore, there can be shown, as it were, a refraction in consciousness: infinity will momentarily pervade finitude, but finitude will nonetheless remain standing as unsuspended and cling as something burdensome and hindering to spirit's striving for infinity.

Only in the form of religiousness that unfolds from the Human fully conscious of itself is the original striving of the human spirit freed from the burdensome limitation of finitude. The religious relation acquires the character of true infinity, because it joins the human spirit with a divine that is indwelling in it, and because it comprehends the whole of human life, all the essential human relations, so that the religious can become [509] the principle of the totality of actual human life. In this religious relation, and only in it, can religious reconciliation become complete; for only in it does spirit not have over against it a divine being that, in the mystery of its incomprehensible will, becomes what is alien to spirit, but a divine in which spirit finds itself again and feels itself confirmed; — and only in it does spirit have full reconciliation in its own interior, since all the essential activities of spirit are in harmony, and since the life of religion is not lived by a flight

from the actuality of human life and by a denial of essential forms of its expression. As the religiousness that pervades the whole of human life, this religiousness of humanity can be designated as the religion of *actuality* and as that which brings a reconciliation *within actuality*, a reconciliation for the *undivided* human essence. It is the expression of the eternal spirit of religiousness as the life-principle of the whole of human life. As religion it is in living inner unity with science and morality. It has its root in the deepest ground of the human essence, and is therefore, since free and conscious spirit has found itself and found this form of religiousness as the expression of its essence, something unshakable and imperishable, independent of the changes of the times.

But precisely the cognition of this includes the cognition of the truth that the positive religions contain. What is most deeply grounded in the human essence must, throughout the whole historical unfolding of human life, have made itself visible, even if only momentarily and incompletely. Spirit's striving for infinity must therefore also reveal itself through the positive religions, and it will do so all the more, the more the *mystical* element in religion comes forward and reflection bound by representation recedes. In the most immediate forms of religious life, in the living, childlike, believing conception, the religious consciousness in its obscure longing comes nearest to the relation of infinity; where reflection gains the upper hand, it moves away from it, and most where theology, finite reflection on religion, becomes the representative of the religious consciousness. Then the separation of finitude between the personal God and man and nature, the [510] opposition between God's essence and the human, the opposition between God's miracle-working activity and the laws of nature and of thought, is carried through as a matter of principle, and with the relation of finitude, which through the separation and the opposition fixes itself in consciousness, the discord is fixed, and the goal toward which the religious consciousness strives is not reached. If theology then becomes half-speculative — and further than that it cannot reach without ceasing to be theology — then all that is attained by the mediation attempted between faith and knowledge, between the antirational and the rational, between the positively religious and the Human, is that consciousness may become befogged and obscured, but there comes no harmony, no actual unity. Then the thinking spirit must seek unity with itself by its own way, and it finds it by immersing itself in its essence and, as it gains the complete concept of the Human, by seeing it include the religious, which does not conflict with thought but confirms thought, which does not flee from life but fills out, ennobles and elevates life. Here, then, the goal is found, and from the goal one can look back with recognition at the stages that lie behind it; but the recognition of their relative truth is inseparably

united with the clear and free consciousness of what separates them from the goal. And therefore there is no striving, either, to preserve the semblance of the unity that in actuality is not present: from the standpoint of free, human religiousness, every neo-rationalist attempt, after having stripped Christianity of everything that makes it a positive religion, to claim for *that* reduced, abstractly rational sublimation of Christianity which one professes the name of the Christian, must be unconditionally rejected as unprincipled and confusing.

Constans.
